Harbaksh Singh was chief of staff, Western Command, in Simla when he was ordered to move to Tezpur.

Niranjan Prasad was formally relieved of his command as GOC 4 Division and in his place was posted Major General Anant Singh Pathania. The new GOC had an impressive combat record, having been awarded a Military Cross in Burma as a young officer and then subsequently a Mahavir Chakra as the commanding officer of 1/5 GR in the Kargil Sector during the 1947-48 Jammu and Kashmir Ops.

But confusion still reigned. The previous day Tezpur had first ordered the withdrawal to Se-la, then changed the order to read Bomdila. Harbaksh Singh, on taking over IV Corps on 24 October had immediately countermanded the order, telling the Artillery Brigade to dig in at Se-la. Accompanied by Palit, he then left for Dirang Dzong by helicopter, where Niranjan Prasad and Anant Pathania were waiting for him. Even as an ad hoc defensive line, it was fairly obvious that Se-la had some advantages. On the flip side, there were quite a few yak trails that ran from Tawang to Dirang Dzong and Nyukmadong that bypassed Se-la. Furthermore, in 1913 Morshead and Bailey, by taking the Poshing-la and Thembang route on their way out of Tibet, had shown that Se-la could be bypassed from the east. However, this was a difficult trail for the Chinese to move a large force along, and Palit felt that by securing the heights overlooking the passes, this threat could be tackled.

Other changes were also taking place. General Thapar, in his wisdom, had decided that the only way to reverse the situation in NEFA was to find commanders who had won gallantry awards in the past to take charge. This was one of the most cockeyed decisions of 1962. Most of these officers were comfortably heading towards retirement. They had to be uprooted from their cushy jobs and sent to a windswept Himalayan pass to fight a battle in near arctic conditions. Palit, who had driven Pathania around Se-la in the morning, was struck by his lack of enthusiasm. ‘…I had received the impression that he seemed dispirited and sluggish. His dejected mood persisted as we continued with our reconnaissance.’

At Jang and Bridge 4, far removed from the drama unfolding at Delhi and Tezpur, there was no sign of the Chinese during the morning hours of 24 October. While Major Rai and his Charlie Company, reinforced with troops from 13 Dogra, scanned the opposite slopes for any activity that would necessitate the blowing up of the bridge, most of the troops who had